UWA | The UNIVERSITY of WEST ALABAMA

-College of Natural Sciences & Mathematics-

From São Paulo to the Cahaba: Doctoral Student Explores Alabama's Rich Amphibian Life

Felipe Floreste, Doctoral Candidate, University of São Paulo in Brazil

A Brazilian scholar's recent visit to the University of West Alabama (UWA) brought international collaboration and exciting research on amphibian life to campus. Felipe R. Floreste, a doctoral student from the University of São Paulo in Brazil, spent almost two weeks at UWA collaborating with Dr. Vania Assis.

Brazilian welcome party for Felipe

Felipe's UWA stay was part of a larger travel itinerary that began in July, including stops at the Joint Meeting of Ichthyologists and Herpetologists in St. Paul, Minnesota, and for molecular biology research at Arkansas State University. His time at UWA kicked off with a Brazilian barbecue welcome party hosted by Dr. Assis, his doctoral advisor, and her husband, Jefferson, at their home. Guests enjoyed authentic Brazilian flavors, including picanha (top sirloin), linguiça (Brazilian sausage), and even the delicacy of chicken hearts.

Amphibian Exploration Event at the CBC

During his visit, Felipe immersed himself in both research and outreach. At the Cahaba Biodiversity Center, he explored Alabama's rich local biodiversity through trips to the river, a cave, and a spring. These adventures led to sightings of snakes, salamanders, frogs, toads, treefrogs, bats, and many insects. He also helped launch UWA's first-ever Amphibian Event at the CBC, which engaged students, faculty, and guests in frog- and salamander-spotting, with all observations recorded in iNaturalist.

Felipe's seminar presentation

Beyond the field, Felipe worked closely with UWA undergraduates, sharing research techniques related to the immunology of non-model species. His visit culminated on Tuesday, September 23, 2025, when he presented an invited seminar titled "Ribbit and resist: advances in amphibian immunology amidst pandemics," to BES in MSB. The presentation sparked valuable discussions and was well-received by a large audience of students and faculty.

Felipe's presence was a wonderful opportunity to strengthen collaborations, highlight the importance of amphibian diversity in the region, and welcome an international scholar into the UWA community. "I am grateful to Felipe (and Dr. Assis) for coming to our campus and sharing his insight and expertise with our faculty and students," said Dean Merida. "These are the types of experiences that help to elevate the research culture of the college and the university."